



FIELD GUIDE · 2026

The AI Automation Starter Guide

A practical playbook for service businesses: where AI moves the needle, how to map your funnel, and the first three systems worth building.



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INTRODUCTION

Most teams don't have an AI problem — they have a funnel problem that AI happens to be very good at solving. This guide skips the hype and walks through the systems we actually build for clients, in the order that compounds fastest. Everything here is field-tested across the local service businesses we work with every day.

CHAPTER 01

Why automate now

The cost of doing things manually isn't the hours — it's the deals that slip while your team is buried in busywork. Automation buys back attention, and attention is where revenue is won.

You don't need to automate everything — just the few repetitive, rules-based tasks that quietly cost you the most. Done right, the first system pays for the next.

TIP

Start with the system closest to revenue — usually outbound or lead routing. Early wins fund the rest and build internal trust.

"We don't just advise. We build — and we run the same systems we sell."

\$320K+

revenue generated

12

industries served

4 yrs

building AI

BEFORE YOU START — A CHECKLIST

- ☐ Document your current funnel, stage by stage.
- ☐ Pick one bottleneck where minutes turn into lost deals.
- ☐ Define one metric that proves the system worked.

CHAPTER 02

Mapping your funnel

Draw the path a customer takes from first contact to paid, and be honest about where it leaks. Most service businesses share the same five stages.

1 Capture

Every enquiry lands in one place, tagged and time-stamped.

2 Respond

A first reply in minutes, not hours — the biggest predictor of closing.

3 Qualify & route

The right enquiries reach the right person, with context.

4 Book

Ready buyers go to your calendar; the rest get nurtured.

5 Follow up

Sequences run until you get a yes or a clear no.

TIP

Put a rough number on each stage. The stage that bleeds the most time or money is the one to automate first.

CHAPTER 03

The first three systems to build

You don't need a grand AI strategy to start. These three systems deliver the fastest, most visible return for almost every service business — and each one makes the next easier to build.

1 Instant lead response

An automatic first reply across your website and WhatsApp, day or night, that answers common questions and captures details.

2 Lead routing & CRM sync

Every enquiry is logged, tagged, and pushed to one system with the context your team needs.

3 Automated follow-up

Personalised sequences that keep nudging a lead over days or weeks. Most replies come after the third touch.

TIP

Build them in this order. Response wins back deals immediately, routing keeps the pipeline clean, and follow-up compounds everything.

CHAPTER 04

Measuring ROI

A system you can't measure is one you'll eventually stop trusting. Every automation pays back in one of three ways — add them up for an honest number you can defend to anyone.

1 Time saved

Hours your team no longer spends on manual work. Multiply hours saved per month by your loaded hourly cost.

2 Revenue gained

Deals you win that used to slip — faster replies, no missed leads, more follow-up.

3 Cost avoided

Hires you didn't need, mistakes you didn't fix, tools you consolidated. Real money that stays in the business.

TIP

Measure 2–3 inputs before and after each system goes live. The before-and-after gap is your proof. Stay conservative.



YOUR MOVE

Let's build your first system.

Book a free call and we'll map your funnel, find the bottleneck costing you the most, and show you exactly what to automate first.

Book a free call

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